

The Russian Figurine

Fiction

Mum wouldn't be back from work for another couple of hours. Anita had been left in charge, but she might as well have been on a different planet – she only had eyes for her phone. She certainly wasn't interested in talking to her brother.

If only he hadn't said what he'd said to her yesterday, at least he wouldn't have been grounded. Apparently, there were some words that everyone knew, but no one was allowed to mention, unless they were sixteen and going through 'a difficult time'. Difficult time? Raul couldn't see what was so difficult for Anita about lying around on your bed, chatting to your friends all day, every day.

For a moment, he thought about his own mates down there, practising their tricks at the skate park. But it just made him more fed up. Turning his back on the window, he gazed around the room for something, anything, to do. There was nothing. They didn't even have a telly now.

He looked around again. Were the boxes by the door full of things to sell or give to charity? Not that he really cared.

Lacking anything else to do, he looked inside the nearest box. Raul was saddened to find various little china figures wrapped up in tissue paper. He had given these to mum as a present over the years.

He picked one of them out and turned it over in his hands. As he did so, memories came flooding back of happier times when Dad was still around. The four of them used to go to the playground in the park, then have lunch in a burger bar. After that, they would wander through the market, looking for things that you couldn't find in normal shops. Mum's favourite stall sold antiques and 'knick-knacks' ('junk' as Dad called it).

One year, a week or two before Mum's birthday, Dad had taken Raul and Anita to the market on their own to choose a birthday present for Mum. The figure Raul was now holding was the one he had chosen for her. It was a pretty shepherd girl with a blue bonnet and white, floor-length dress. He hated it, but Mum adored it.

On the base, he discovered a small hole. For no particular reason, he peered inside. The middle was smooth and white, and not very interesting. But then something caught his eye. Just where it narrowed to the neck, he noticed a scrap of paper stuffed into the hollow of the head. But how could he get it out?

A pair of tweezers provided the answer. After a couple of frustrating fails, he managed to tug it free.

Carefully, he unrolled the scrap to find a hand-written message in a language he didn't understand. But if he was right, it was a brief letter that looked like it had been written by someone called 'Nicholas' to 'Anastasia'. This was an exciting discovery and not one he was willing to share...